Article 111 of its constitution to establish a three-member interim leadership council to rule until a new Supreme Leader could be appointed. The council consists of president Masoud Pezeshkian, chief justice Gholam-Hossein Mohseni-Eje'i and Ayatollah Alireza Arafi, a member of the Guardian Council and head of Iran's seminaries.

As Gaddam Dharmendra, former Indian ambassador to Iran, points out, "Let's not forget this is a 47-year-old deeply embedded ideological regime. Successive generations of people, who are now in ruling positions, have been weaned on this ideology. Having said that, there will be contentious factions. But on the issue of regime integrity, preventing regime collapse, they are completely united. We should have no doubt about it." There is speculation that

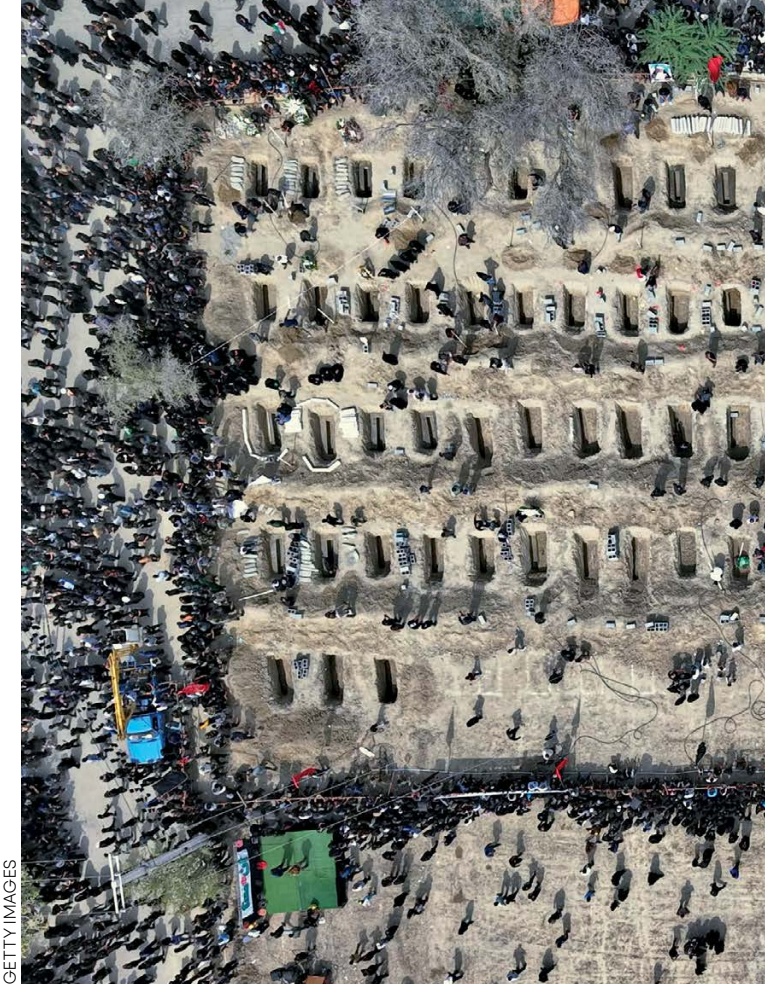
WITHIN IRAN, TRUMP AND HIS CABAL ARE BEING CALLED 'THE EPSTEIN GANG', ARCHETYPES OF INJUSTICE, AND KHAMENEI AS HUSAYN, THE ARCHETYPE OF MARTYRDOM

the next Supreme Leader could be Mojtaba Khamenei, Khamenei's second son. "If that happens," says Dr Hasan Alhasan, senior fellow for Middle East Policy at the International Institute for Strategic Studies in Bahrain, "he is cut from the same cloth as his father, and we are unlikely to see a shift in Iran's position under the new leadership. The irony is that perhaps Trump has already instigated regime change in Iran, turning it into a hereditary monarchy."

IRAN'S GAME PLAN

Alhasan believes the duration of the war may ultimately be determined not by ideology or rhetoric but by cold military arithmetic. He points to both tactical and strategic factors that could influence the outcome. On the tactical side, he says Iran's ability to sustain its missile and drone strikes on Israel-US targets will depend on the depth of its stockpiles and the resilience of its launch infrastructure. Equally critical is the capacity of the US and its regional partners to continue intercepting those projectiles. Missile defence systems can blunt attacks, but they are not limitless. Interceptors are expensive, inventories finite and the strain of daily barrages quickly compound. If Iran's arsenals prove deeper than expected, or if defences begin to thin, the tempo of the war could shift dramatically.

Beyond the battlefield, a broader strategic contest is unfolding across the Gulf. Iran's game plan seems to have two intertwined goals. The first is to pressure America's regional partners by striking, or threatening, civilian and critical infrastructure such as ports, energy facilities and



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WAGES OF WAR
A satellite image shows smoke billowing from a ship off Bandar Abbas along the Strait of Hormuz, Mar. 2